

door. I determined not to buy anything that cost \$10 or more unless I waited 30 days and got 3 more prices. Also, I could not have more than one item on my list at a time. I continued that plan for over six months without purchasing a single item on my chart. The reason was obvious: once I left the store, the impulse passed, and before the 30 days were out, I'd identified something else I wanted more. Later I discovered a plan that was infallible: stay out of the stores.

● GIFTS

It is unfortunate that we place so much importance on gifts. But since we do, they should be a part of the budget. You should consider the amount you will spend on gifts every year and plan for their purchase.

Regardless of your financial status, in debt or otherwise, determine to bring gift-giving under control. Here are a few hints that may help you:

(1) Keep an event calendar during the year and plan ahead for the gifts. Buy on sale. Shop for birthdays and anniversaries ahead of time, so you don't have to buy quickly.

(2) Initiate some family crafts and make some of the gifts that you need. Not only will making gifts help bring your family together, but they also reflect more love.

(3) Draw names for selected gifts rather than giving each family member something.

(4) Do not buy gifts on credit. Credit reflects very little love. It would be much better to make something with your own hands rather than borrow in order to give.

(5) Help your children earn money for gifts. You also can help your children to be aware of others' needs. Perhaps rather than giving a family member a gift, they could give to someone who really needs it.

Next I'll go, item by item, through a typical family budget and give guideline percentages for each category. Also, I will offer suggestions I have gleaned by counseling with many couples that may help you to be better stewards.